because the ideological/social aspects of politics were seen as less significant and rewarding. Many of the Congress's organizational strengths, its structure and culture became its nemesis over the course of time. The strength of the Congress party was its 'umbrella' character, where it could accommodate diverse and conflicting political visions. This helped the Congress evolve into the 'Congress System' that paid it rich electoral dividends. But in time, when ideological clarity began to blur and the anticolonial inspiration and idealism waned, the accommodative character degenerated. Instead, the party organization descended into anarchy, indiscipline and a space of personalized networks. Contending visions became contentious factions vying for power and power over the party organization. The Congress's organization today is marked by pragmatic machinations and transactional quid pro quo. With the burden of such a culture, new leadership emerged for its ability to manage pragmatic calculations, which, in turn, changed its social character to one of middlemen and networkers. With the additional burden of money and muscle in electoral politics, the Congress outsourced its leadership to those who were already rich or locally wielded power. Today, when the Congress is staring at a steep ideological challenge, its leaders are on a weak wicket. In fact, most leaders do not understand the place of ideology and policy in politics.

It is against this backdrop that one needs to assess the role and impact of the Bharat Jodo Yatra. For a long time, it seems that Rahul Gandhi has been acutely aware of the Congress party's historical trajectory. In a conversation with a friend, who seems to have raised this question on the Congress's organizational culture, Rahul Gandhi reportedly mused out loud how he could repair an air conditioner that was running! His repeated interventions to stem infighting and indiscipline also throw light on his deep dissatisfaction with the state of affairs within. Did this understanding get reflected in the messaging of the BJY and does it have the potential to turn things around for the Congress party?

In the course of my own interactions with Congress leaders at various levels, I found it amusing that many continue to think that Rahul Gandhi